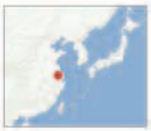
COLD WAR CONFLICTS

AFTER THE END OF World War II the United States and it allies became involved in global resistance to the spread of Communism. Communist triumph in the Chinese Civil War in 1950 was followed by a major war in Korea, where Communist North Korean and Chinese forces fought South Korean and US-led United Nations forces. The navies of the United States and its allies were deployed on a large scale through the three years of the war, operating unchallenged around the whole Korean peninsula. As well as the amphibious operations such as that at Inchon in September 1950, they provided close air support for UN ground forces with carrier aircraft, and flattened North Korean coastal towns with naval gunfire. The fact that both the Communist Soviet Union and the United States possessed nuclear weapons deterred them from fighting one another directly, but a dangerous confrontation developed after Fidel Castro came to power in Cuba in 1959 and allied his country with the Soviets. The possibility that the Soviets might defy a naval blockade imposed on Cuba by the United States during the missile crisis of 1962 brought the world close to nuclear disaster.

THE COLD WAR

YANGTZE INCIDENT



Date April 20–July 31, 1949
Forces British: 4 frigates; Chinese: shore batteries
Losses British: none; Chinese: none

Location Yangtze River, near Jiangyin, China

On April 20, 1949, the British frigate HMS *Amethyst* sailed up the politically fraught waters of the Yangtze River in China. At this time, China was split between Chiang Kai-Shek's beleaguered Nationalists and the Communists of Mao Tse-tung's ascendant People's Liberation Army (PLA), with the Yangtze forming one of the frontlines in the conflict. *Amethyst* was tasked with shipping supplies to the British community at Nanking, and with the relief of the guardship HMS *Consort* stationed there, a journey that would take it through the heart of a war zone. From the outset, *Amethyst* was shelled at close range by several PLA shore batteries, resulting in over 50 hits that killed 17 crewmen and wounded another 30. The ship's commanding officer, Lieutenant Commander Bernard Skinner, was among those who were killed during the shelling.

RESCUE MISSION

With the *Amethyst* run aground off Rose Island near Jiangyin, HMS *Consort* launched a spectacular high-speed rescue effort, knocking out several Chinese shore batteries before being forced to retreat. Other rescue attempts by the vessels HMS *Black Swan* and HMS *London* were similarly roughly handled, resulting in many dead and wounded. Thereafter, *Amethyst* remained trapped for 14 weeks during negotiations—during this time the ship's company (under Lieutenant Commander John Kerans) managed to complete major temporary repairs. On the night of July 30–31, *Amethyst* fired up her engines and made a break for the sea in a storm of gunfire. The ship punched through the boom at the mouth of the Yangtze River and made open water and safety. The incident was cheered in Britain, and the crew were hailed as heroes.

THE INCHON LANDINGS

In August 1950 United Nations and South Korean forces were pinned in the Pusan area of southern Korea. UN Supreme Commander General Douglas MacArthur planned a bold amphibious operation to land troops behind North Korean lines at Inchon. The conditions for landings were difficult. Inchon had one of the most extreme tidal ranges in the world—around 36 ft (11 m) maximum variation between low and high tide—and was surrounded by treacherous mudflats. The two sea approaches, the Flying Fish Channel and the Eastern Channel, were narrow and difficult to negotiate. The approaches were dominated by the fortified island of Wolmi-do, which would have to be captured first. On the other hand, the UN forces had total command of the sea and air. The operation, codenamed Chromite, was set for September 15, when the tide would be high enough to allow large tank landing craft to reach the shore.

THE KOREAN WAR



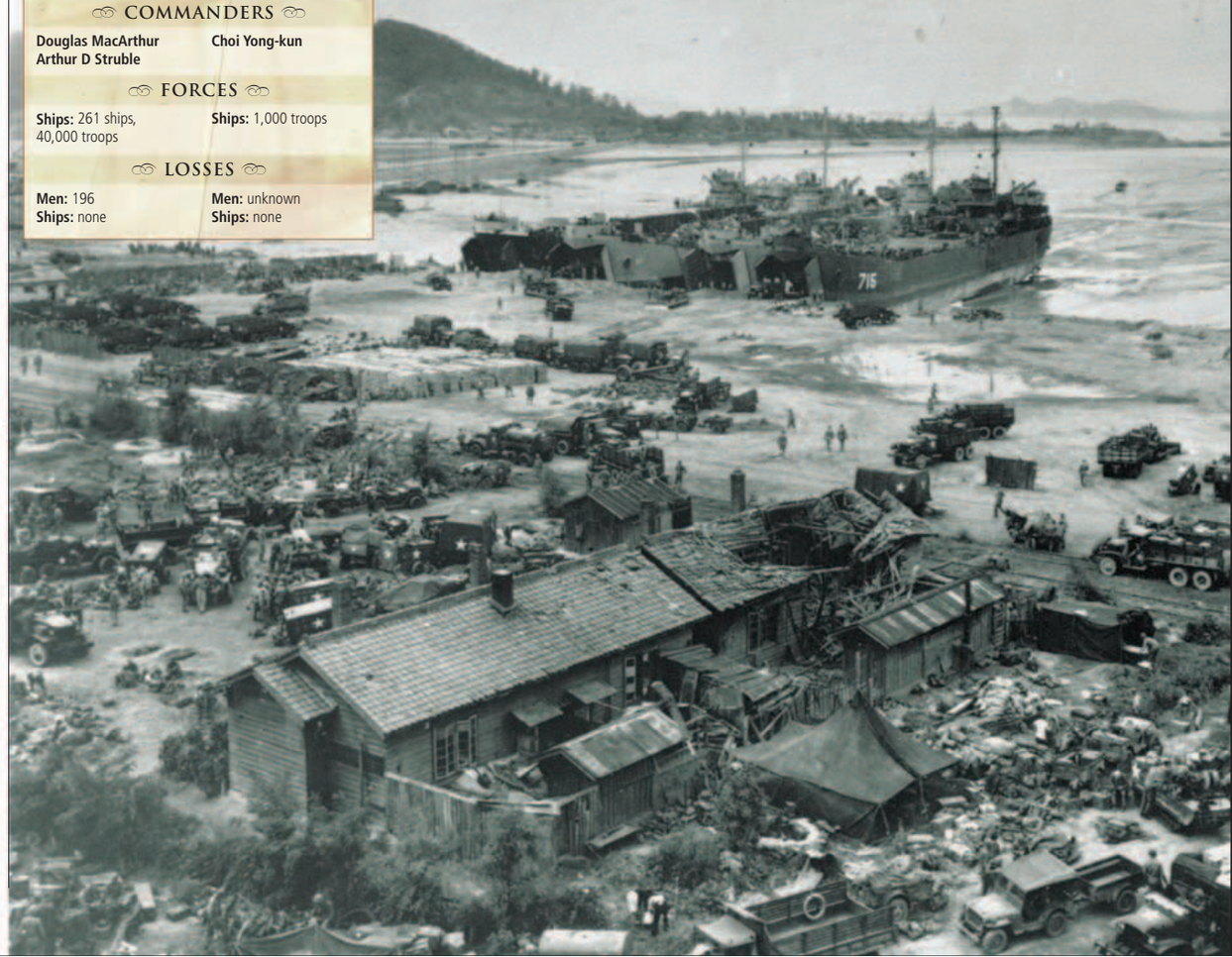
THE INCHON LANDINGS

Date	September 15, 1950
Location	South Korea
Result	UN victory

COMBATANTS	
UNITED STATES	**NORTH KOREA**
COMMANDERS	
Douglas MacArthur **Arthur D Struble**	**Choi Yong-kun**
FORCES	
Ships: 261 ships, 40,000 troops	**Ships:** 1,000 troops
LOSSES	
Men: 196 **Ships:** none	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** none

AMPHIBIOUS OPERATION

A force of 261 ships, including British and Canadian vessels as well as American, assembled under Vice Admiral Arthur D. Struble, although preparations were disrupted by a typhoon in early September. Diversionary attacks were mounted to disperse the North Korean defenses, but Inchon itself was thoroughly softened up with strikes by carrier aircraft. Seven destroyers made



US troops land at Inchon
In the course of operations around the port of Inchon, UN forces landed some 50,000 US troops. The Inchon landings led to the recapture of Seoul and turned around UN fortunes in the Korean War.